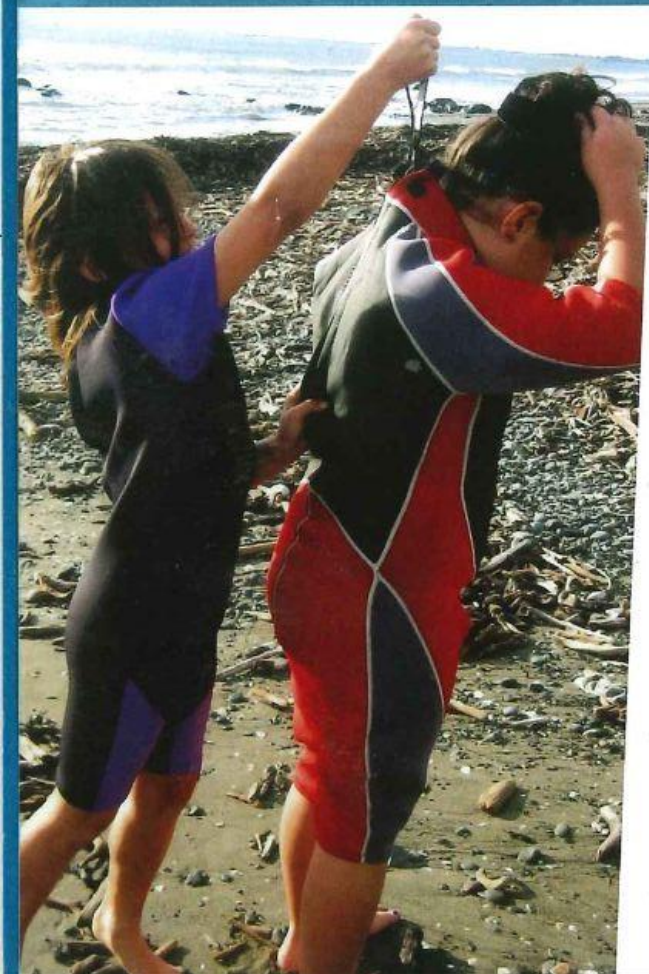




Tiakina a Tangaroa – Protect Our Seas

by Jill MacGregor

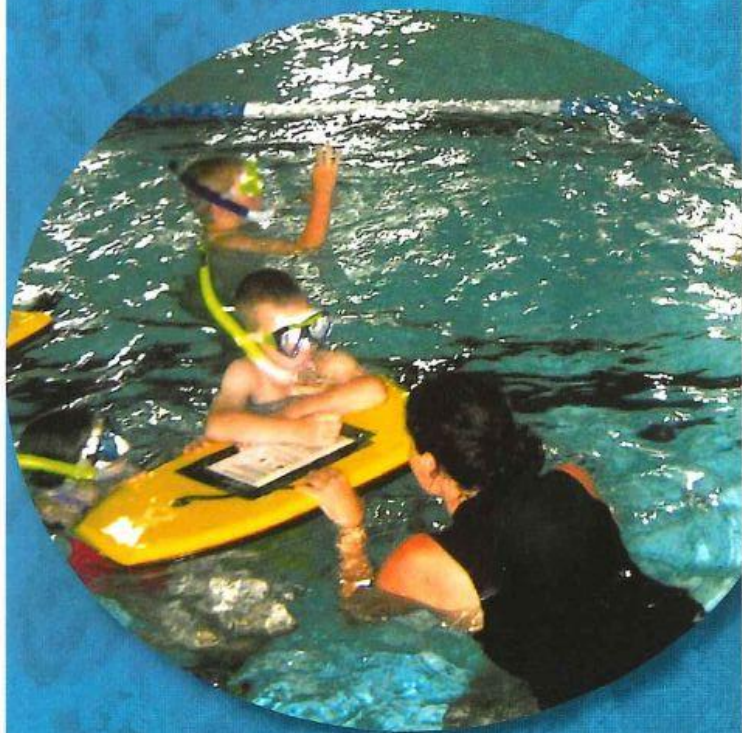


“We’re going snorkelling,” our teacher said one morning.

Our class was learning about marine reserves. Marine reserves are areas that have been set aside to protect all the plants and animals in the sea and on the foreshore. People can swim, dive, and snorkel in the reserve, but they can’t take anything away.

We wanted to find out what difference it made to plants and animals when an area became a marine reserve. We thought that the best way to find this out would be by comparing a “protected” marine reserve with an “unprotected” beach. And to do that, we’d need to get wet. Twice!

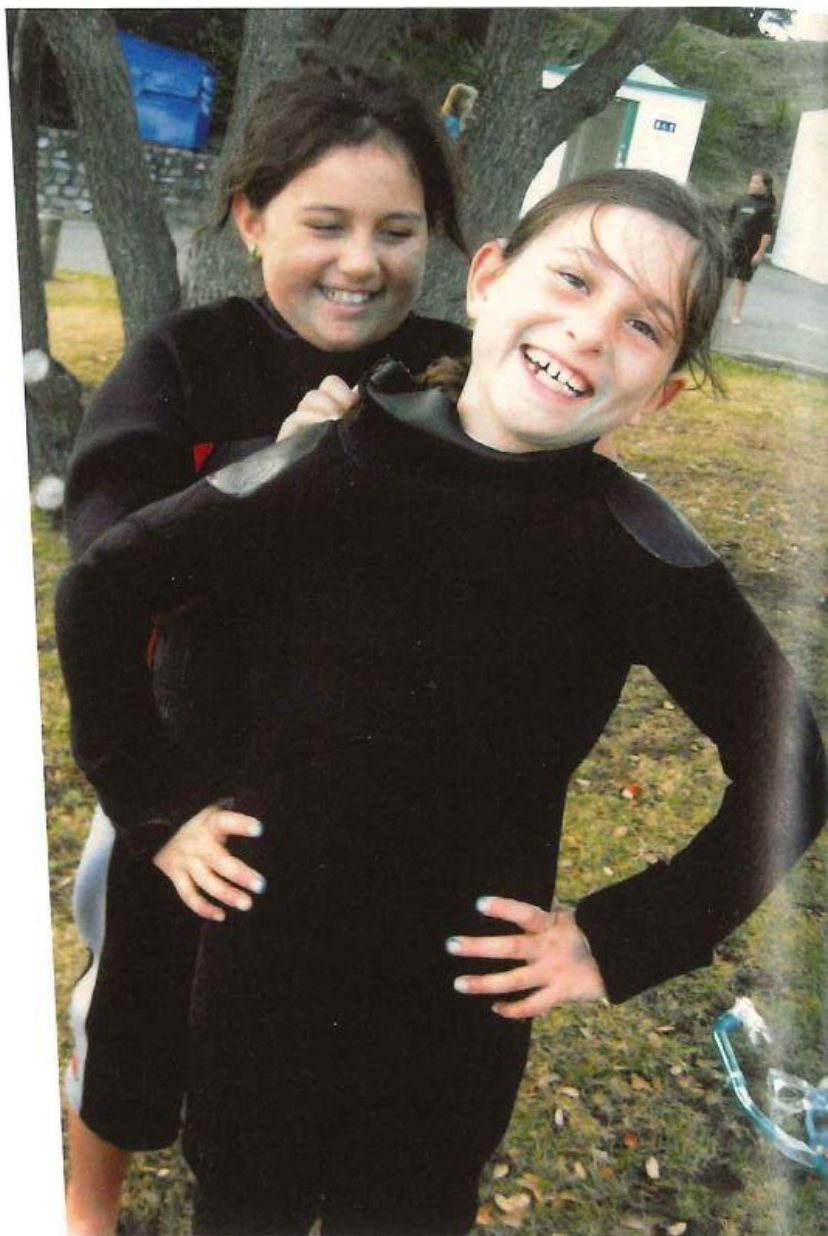
Before we could snorkel in the sea, we practised our skills at the pool. We learnt the hand signals to use in an emergency, and we learnt what to do if our snorkels filled up with water or our masks fogged up.



Our first visit was to an “unprotected” local beach where people could fish, drive motor boats or jet skis, and collect kaimoana.

Before we got into the water, we checked our gear and helped each other into our wetsuits. We made sure we all knew the safety rules, and we put out the dive flag to warn passing boats we were there. A lookout person stayed on shore.

We had to walk backwards into the sea with our flippers on. Sophie thought we looked like a pod of clumsy seals! The wetsuits helped us to stay afloat and kept us warm.





We each held onto a bodyboard and peered down into the sea. Everything looked much bigger and closer under water.



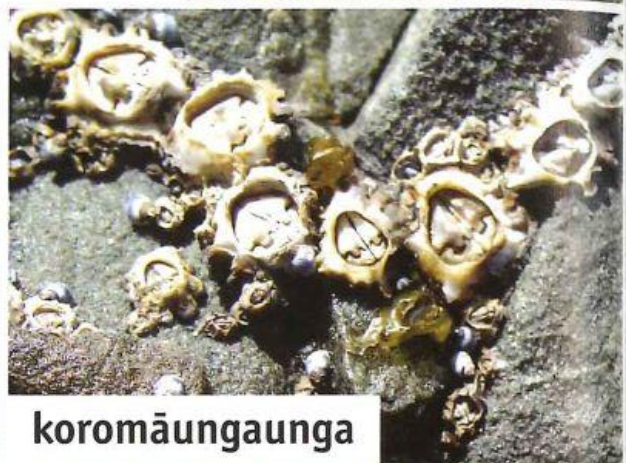
The water was quite murky, but we saw **pūpū** (cat's eyes), **ngaeti** (periwinkles), and **koromāungaunga** (barnacles) on the rocks. Lots of **paketi** (spotties) darted around among clumps of seaweed. **Pāpaka** (hermit crabs) and **long-armed brittle-stars** scuttled into crevices when they saw us.



pūpū



ngaeti



koromāungaunga



pāpaka



long-armed brittle-stars



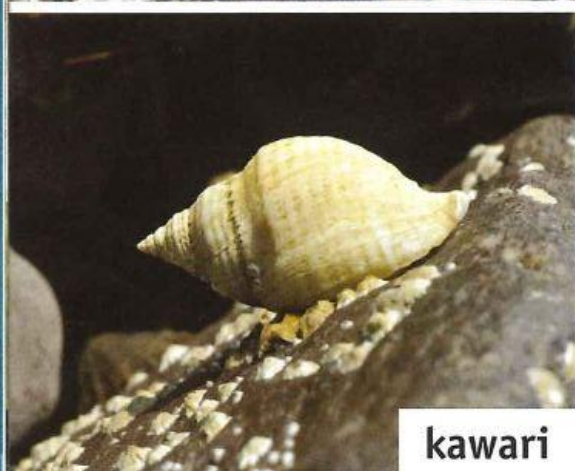
paketi



We were disappointed to find empty pāua shells, glass, and tin cans lying on the seabed. Plastic bottles and pieces of tangled fishing line swirled in the rock pools. Litter had been blown into the sea from the beach or dropped from boats.

We felt sad that no one seemed to be looking after the children of Tangaroa, the creatures of the sea. If we don't look after them now, they won't be there for our children in the future.





kawari



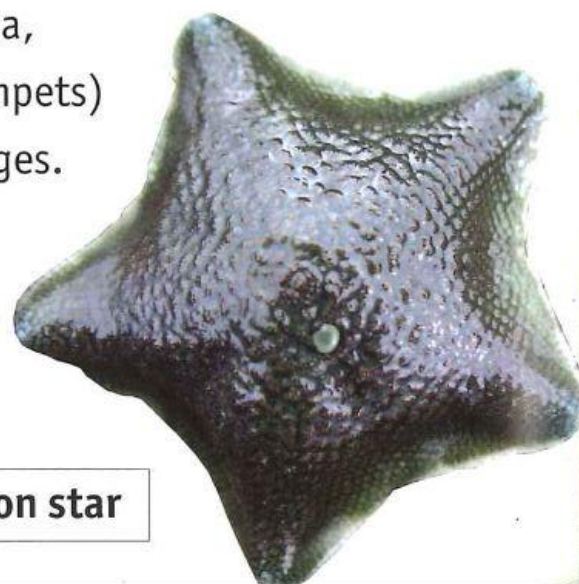
ngākihi



kuku

A week later, we explored a “protected” area – Kapiti Island Marine Reserve. Straight away, we could tell that this was a special place where creatures lived and thrived without being disturbed. The water was crystal clear, and there was plenty to see below the surface.

Huge **pāua** and **kawari** (whelks) shared their rocky home with **kōtore moana** (sea anemones) and **cushion stars**. Clusters of tiny **kuku** (mussels), koromāungaunga, and **ngākihi** (limpets) clung to the ledges.



cushion star



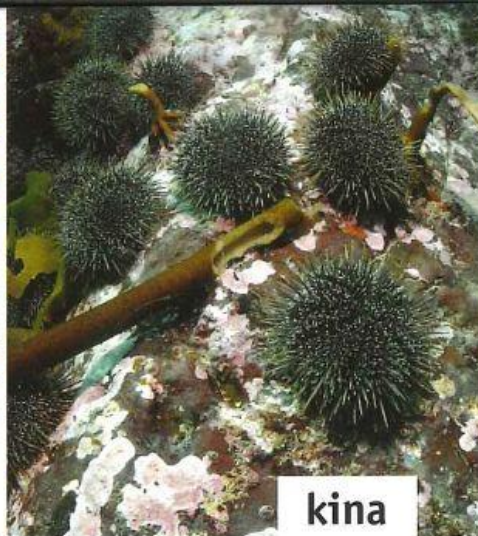
pāua



kōtore moana



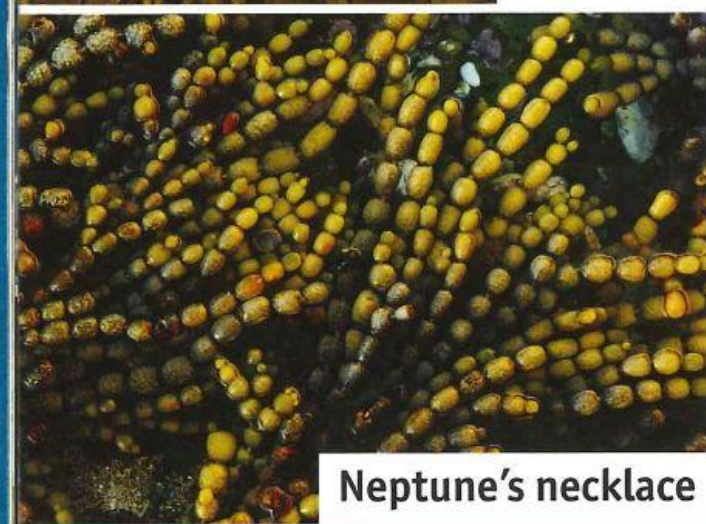
rimurapa



kina



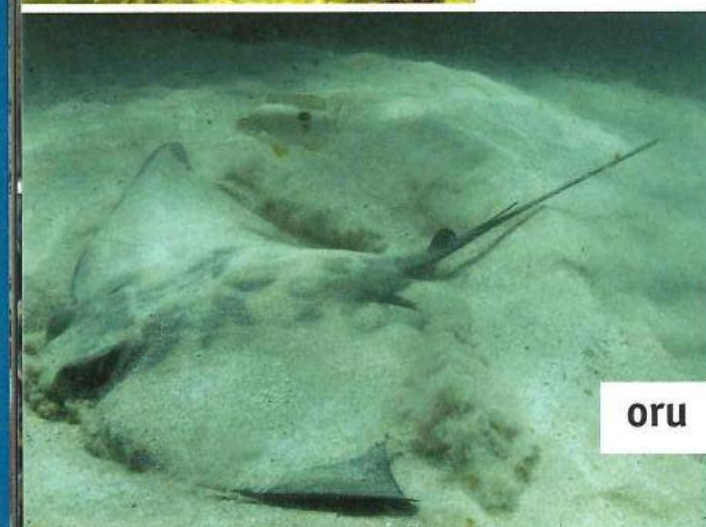
hautai



Neptune's necklace



sea lettuce



oru



pātiki

A mass of shiny, reddish-brown **rimurapa** (bull kelp) swayed with the currents. Spiky **kina** grazed on beds of colourful **hautai** (sponges), **Neptune's necklace**, and **sea lettuce**.

Whole schools of **tarakihi** cruised past us, so close that we wanted to reach out and touch them. We saw a baby **oru** (stingray) and a **pātiki** (flounder) resting on the seabed.

We felt sure that the children of Tangaroa were happy and healthy here.



tarakihi



Since we had seen what a difference a marine reserve can make, we wanted to share our experience with others.

We organised a sponsored beach parade. We wrote waiata and made banners to inspire others to respect Tangaroa and all the creatures of the sea.

The funds we raised at our parade will go towards buying more snorkel gear so that children in other schools can learn more about marine reserves, too.

Protect our seas for the future!
Tiakina a Tangaroa! ■